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From the editor-in-chief

Higher education has never figured higher in the priority list of parents and their college-bound offspring. The global economic crisis accompanied by rising unemployment has convulsed the job market. In India, Human Resource Development Minister Kapil Sibal is desperately trying to balance changes in higher education with the clamour for caste reservations. Against that backdrop, INDIA TODAY's 14th annual survey of the country's best colleges, the recognised benchmark for academic excellence, acquires added weight. Over the last 13 years, we have constantly fine-tuned the methodology and ranking process. This year, we have increased the weightage given to factual findings as opposed to perception to make it more accurate. The process began in end-2009 when our partner The Nielsen Company conducted research to determine the best undergraduate colleges in arts, science, commerce, engineering, medicine and law. For arts, science and commerce, colleges in 12 major cities were considered. For engineering, medicine and law, colleges from all over India were considered. The initial process generates the list of colleges using secondary data sources such as published reports which results in a comprehensive list of more than 1,500 colleges.

After this, education experts in each city were administered a structured questionnaire based on five parameters—Reputation of College, Quality of Academic Input, Student Care, Infrastructure and Job Prospects. A different panel of experts was asked to rate the colleges in their respective streams, this time with a national perspective. To determine the overall rankings, colleges were contacted for factual data. The final rankings in each of the six streams were arrived at by combining perceptual scores and factual scores to give the overall score. For additional credibility, the opinion of nearly 1,000 educationists at the level of principals, heads of department and deans was captured for various stages of the study. The big news this year is the reaction of college administrators to the impending arrival of foreign educational institutions which will obviously have a major impact on higher education. Most experts we surveyed believe that foreign colleges would impact India in three ways: a surrender from some, a collaboration by others and, more importantly, a sharp rise in the levels of educational excellence.

What also emerges from the survey is a widespread desire to make undergraduate learning more flexible and more relevant to the real world to enable students to perform better in their jobs when they enter the workforce. Almost all respondents cite infrastructure as the biggest challenge to the demands of the new knowledge age. Every year after the survey is published I get several complaints about the results in particular from those who are not happy with the rankings. This feedback enables us to refine our survey methodology every year but is also an indication of how seriously the survey is taken. In this fiercely competitive field, we can't please everybody but we are constantly working to make the survey more credible. Our colleges need to become the launchpad for entry into the knowledge economy and to be dynamic centres of academic excellence. Hopefully, our survey helps this process by benchmarking colleges against each other.

(Aroon Purie)



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